was proclaimed in August 1969 with the goal of peacefully overthrowing the Ne Win regime. If the party were not allowed to operate on Burmese soil, the alternative would be armed insurrection. The threat was perceived as legitimate since U Nu embarked on a global tour of prominent countries. Even more threatening was the decision of numerous disgruntled groups to form the United National Liberation Front coalition led by U Nu, to forcibly oppose the Revolutionary Council.

The antigovernment alliance quickly disintegrated. In general, the coalition lacked any sort of organizational base. Furthermore, strong rivalries emerged among the different leaders of the factions. Numerous operational failures, including a commando raid to steal supplies and ammunition, failed miserably. By the late 1960s, the Burmese military was a well-financed, well-trained fighting force that could soundly defeat the insurgent forces. A final blow to the resistance movement came when U Nu was asked by the Thai authorities to leave the country. Without the base of operation in Thailand, the movement was doomed.

The Revolutionary Council decided to officially formulate a political party that would mirror the goals of the “Burmese Way to Socialism” and thus formed the Burma Socialist Program Party (BSPP) in 1971. It took almost a decade for the military dictatorship to form a political movement that would be open to mass membership. The goals of the party included drafting a new constitution and a return to civilian rule. Input from the population was encouraged. The process would be painfully time consuming and committees solicited input from all sectors of the citizenry. Multiple drafts were drawn up over a three-year period in which the BSPP claimed that over eight million people provided input. The final step in the process was to demilitarize the political process by having the key governmental officials resign their military posts.

Under the new structure, Burma was to become a one-party socialist state. The population was to vote on a referendum to approve the new constitution. The legislative branch would be unicameral with members elected to four-year terms. The legislature would elect the state council and eventually a chairman of the council. A key goal of the new administration was to eliminate excessive bureaucracy. In theory, more power would be in the hands of the population. The new governmental system officially started